

"I was still a kid but playing in a man's game, recalled Francis, now 24 and rated one of the top play-

Birmingham rejected the offer, and when Goodwin refused to get into an "auction" for Francis' services,

dropping the bat and screaming "I want that's why."

Especially because of Freddie Goodwin.

In 2009, Mauch would catch Connie Mack



GENE MAUCH IN THE '60s
"What did I get myself into?"

By BOB FOWLER
Minneapolis Star Staff Writer

There was a time when Gene Mauch wondered if he had made the right decision in choosing major league managing as a career. Putting out fires seemed more secure than summoning a relief pitcher, taming ligers appeared to be safer than trying to beat Detroit.

"I had that feeling right after my first big league game as a manager," he recalled.

That was in April, 1960.

He was about to start his third season as the manager of the Minneapolis Millers that year when Eddie Sawyer of the Philadelphia Phillies quit after his team had lost its first game.

PHILLIES OFFICIALS called Mauch.

"I had had a couple of major league offers, but had turned them down," he said. "One reason I accepted the Phillie job was that I believed the team had a good pitching staff."

Andy Cohen managed the Phillies to a victory in their second game that year, then Mauch arrived.

"We played the Milwaukee Braves in my first game," he said. "They had Hank Aaron, Eddie Mathews, Joe Adcock and a lot of other sluggers. And they beat us 13-2."

"After that game I wasn't sure I'd make it

through another game. I sat in the clubhouse and thought, 'What have I gotten myself into here?'"

But Mauch did survive that opening defeat and returned to manage another game.

"The next day the Braves won 12-5," he said. "I thought, 'Well, it's an improvement.'"

Mauch has missed only a few games since making his debut 19 years ago — when he was fired after 55 games by the Phillies in 1968. He went on to manage Montreal, an expansion team, for seven years. Three times he was named the National League's manager of the year, but he never directed a team to a pennant. Then after being released by the Expos following the 1975 season, he was hired by the Twins.

Now the 52-year-old man, who leads present major league managers in seniority, is about to enter the record books.

THE TWINS WILL open a four-game weekend series in Oakland with a doubleheader tonight.

The first game will be Mauch's 2,858th as a major league manager, tying him for 10th place on the all-time seniority list with Clark Griffith.

Obviously, when the second game begins he will move into 10th place alone.

"Frankly, that doesn't mean much to me," Mauch said. "I mean, I'm a long way from being No. 1."

Yes, he would have to manage until he's 83 to top Connie Mack's 7,801-game total.

It isn't surprising to those who know him that Mauch is as enthused about games 2,858 and 2,859 as he was about Nos. 1 and 2 in 1960.

Despite their 35-42 record, the Twins have won four straight and five of their last six games. They are only five games behind first-place Oakland in the American League West.

MAUCH WILL START two left handers, veteran Geoff Zahn (7-6) and rookie Darrell Jackson (1-1) against two Oakland right-handed pitchers, Steve Renko (3-3) and Rick Langford (1-6).

"I was enthused about this club a month ago," the manager said. "I guess I was wrong because just when I thought we would start winning we lost five straight games."

"Now, I feel that way again. I think our young players have matured and we're ready to get into the thick of the race in our division."

So even if the Twins falter tonight and lose by scores of 13-2 and 12-5, their manager isn't about to sit in the clubhouse and wonder, "What have I gotten myself into here?"

If nothing else, in 19 major league campaigns he has learned that baseball is indeed a long season.



GENE MAUCH IN THE '70s
Knows it's a long season